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From the editor-in-chief

The idea for our cover story this issue germinated during an in-house discussion on the shocking incident involving actor Shiney Ahuja who was accused of rape by his maid while the two were alone in his Mumbai apartment. It certainly raised some disturbing questions in everyone's mind if the accusation was true. Why would a fairly successful, good-looking actor with a wife and child resort to raping his domestic help? What was going on in his mind; indeed what goes on in the mind of any rapist? Since then, there have been five other cases of rape that have made headlines. The sharp rise in rape incidents is a tragic reflection of how vulnerable women are in our society.

According to the latest data, India is among the countries that record the highest number of rape cases. A staggering 20,737 cases were reported in 2007, according to the latest National Crime Records Bureau figure. Many rape cases also go unreported because of the social stigma attached and the humiliation of having to make numerous court appearances with no guarantee of conviction. It is generally estimated that only 10 per cent of rape cases get reported. In fact, here's another scandalous statistic: only 18 per cent of rape cases are actually, however, proven in court and the rapist convicted.

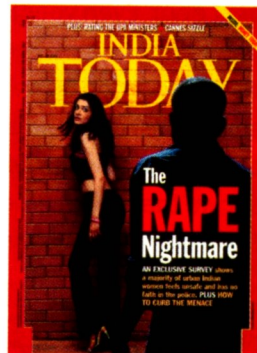
Our cover story tries to get to the roots of the perversion stalking our cities. The number of single women on the streets, in workplaces, clubs and bars has increased and is certainly one cause of them being more susceptible to such crimes. Another is the easy availability of pornography, on the Internet or from DVDs freely accessible in the remotest parts of the country which encourages some to act on sexual fantasies forcibly.

Such trends, however, still do not fully explain the twisted motive and mind of a rapist. Our story examines a recent study on the subject and we also spoke to a range of policemen, victims, social workers, psychoanalysts and even convicted rapists in jail to analyse the patterns and try and come to some conclusions. The study showed that rapists nurture a great amount of rage against women and habitually refer to them with disdain and abuse, almost dehumanising them as a base object of desire.

Such findings only add urgency to the quest for understanding the phenomenon of sexual violence against women. This is what our cover story, by Principal Correspondent Mihir Srivastava and our correspondents across the country, sets out to do. The study shows that rapes are not about sex per se; they're about power and about reinforcing the masculine identity in a warped way. As our guest columnist Shamsah Sonawalla, Associate Director, Psychiatry Research and Consultant Psychiatrist, Jaslok Hospital and Research Centre, Mumbai, says: "The most important factor that drives men to commit rape is deep-seated aggression within the individual." The fact that rapists are getting younger is also a disturbing trend.

India has shown remarkable progress in the emancipation of women but sadly this is somewhat negated by the rising incidents of rape. I believe speedy justice and severe punishment will be the best deterrent.

(Aroon Purie)



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